

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nyaya-Vaisesika (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika) - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Nyaya-Vaisesika (Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika)

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 categories (padārthas)
- 2 sixteen Nyāya topics of inquiry
- 3 seven Vaiśeṣika ontological categories
- 4 inference (anumāna)
- 5 classical Vaiśeṣika accepts perception and inference
- 6 from perceived cause to unperceived effect (pūrvavat)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Nyaya-Vaisesika (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which statement best captures the historical division and later convergence of Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika?

A. Nyāya initially foregrounded means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and debate, Vaiśeṣika categories and ontology; later they formed an integrated realist system B. Vaiśeṣika supplied only ethics, while Nyāya supplied atomism C. The two schools remained doctrinally unrelated D. Nyāya alone accepted external objects, while Vaiśeṣika was idealist

Answer: A. Nyāya initially foregrounded means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and debate, Vaiśeṣika categories and ontology; later they formed an integrated realist system

Explanation: Nyāya's sixteen-topic logical-epistemic analysis and Vaiśeṣika's category (padārtha) ontology became mutually supporting. "Convergence" does not erase differences of origin; it identifies the mature Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika synthesis.

2. Which is the complete later Vaiśeṣika list of categories (padārthas)?

A. Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), saṃśaya, prayojana, drṣṭānta, established conclusion (siddhānta), avayava and hypothetical reasoning (tarka) B. Dravya, quality (guṇa), motion or action (karma), sāmānya, viśeṣa, inherence (samavāya) and absence (abhāva) C. Primordial material nature (prakṛti), conscious witness (puruṣa), determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra), tanmātras, bhūtas and indriyas D. Dravya, quality (guṇa), motion or action (karma) and sāmānya only

Answer: B. Dravya, quality (guṇa), motion or action (karma), sāmānya, viśeṣa, inherence (samavāya) and absence (abhāva)

Explanation: The mature list contains six positive categories plus absence (abhāva) as the seventh. Kaṇāda's older enumeration is commonly treated as six, so an answer should not project the later addition backwards without qualification.

3. Which set contains only the nine Vaiśeṣika dravyas?

A. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, ego, intellect, pleasure, pain B. Earth, water, fire, air, atoms, universals, inherence, absence, self C. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, time, direction/space, self and mind D. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, time, action and moral consequence (karma), dharma and adharma

Answer: C. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, time, direction/space, self and mind

Explanation: The nine are pṛthivī, ap, tejas, vāyu, ākāśa, kāla, dik, enduring self (ātman) and sensory mind (manas). Cognition, pleasure, dharma and adharma belong to quality (guṇa), while universals, inherence and absence are separate categories (padārthas).

4. In Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, cognition, pleasure and desire are best classified as

A. motions of sensory mind (manas) B. the essence of self C. independent substances D. qualities that inhere in self

Answer: D. qualities that inhere in self

Explanation: They are qualities (guṇas) of enduring self (ātman) arising under suitable conditions. This is why Nyāya can affirm an enduring self even when manifest consciousness is absent; it must not be assimilated to Advaita's self-as-consciousness.

5. What is motion or action (karma) as a Vaiśeṣika category (padārtha)?

- A. Physical motion/action, classically divided into upward, downward, contraction, expansion and locomotion B. The unseen allocator of karmic fruit C. The universal relation between cause and effect D. Moral merit and demerit alone

Answer: A. Physical motion/action, classically divided into upward, downward, contraction, expansion and locomotion

Explanation: Here motion or action (karma) means physical movement, not moral karma. It inheres in substance and helps produce conjunction and disjunction; dharma and adharma, by contrast, are listed among qualities.

6. Why does Vaiśeṣika admit sāmānya as real?

- A. Because universals are spatial wholes divided among instances B. Because recurrent classification and common predication require an objective one-in-many ground C. Because only universals possess causal motion D. Because every word must denote one eternal sound

Answer: B. Because recurrent classification and common predication require an objective one-in-many ground

Explanation: Cow-ness is treated as one eternal universal inhering in many cows. The school's realism opposes Buddhist apoha; however, jāti-bādhakas restrict the indiscriminate multiplication of universals.

7. What work does viśeṣa perform in the system?

- A. It converts memory into perception B. It explains negative cognition C. It individuates qualitatively similar eternal substances D. It connects separable substances temporarily

Answer: C. It individuates qualitatively similar eternal substances

Explanation: Viśeṣa is ultimate particularity in atoms, selves, sensory mind (manas), ākāśa, time and direction. It is said to be self-differentiating (svato-vyāvartaka), a regress-stopping posit whose plausibility depends on accepting plural eternal reals.

8. Which description of inherence (samavāya) is most accurate?

- A. Any relation of objects that cannot presently be pulled apart B. A produced quality between two substances C. Identity of a thing with its own nature D. A sui-generis eternal inherence linking specified ontologically dependent relata

Answer: D. A sui-generis eternal inherence linking specified ontologically dependent relata

Explanation: Inherence (samavāya) holds in standard pairs such as whole-parts, substance-quality and universal-instance. Inseparability is necessary but not a complete definition; the relation is not merely tight conjunction or generic dependence.

9. A book resting on a table and brown colour in the table illustrate respectively

- A. saṃyoga and inherence (samavāya) B. two instances of inherence (samavāya) C. two instances of saṃyoga D. inherence (samavāya) and saṃyoga

Answer: A. saṃyoga and inherence (samavāya)

Explanation: Book and table are independently existent substances in produced, destructible conjunction. Brown colour depends on a substance and inheres in it; confusing these erases the contrast between contingent contact and constitutive dependence.

10. Which sequence correctly describes the four abhāvas?

- A. Antecedent, efficient, material and non-inherent absence B. Prior, posterior, absolute and mutual absence C. Prior, mutual, conjunctive and inherential absence D. Temporary, permanent, perceptual and inferential absence

Answer: B. Prior, posterior, absolute and mutual absence

Explanation: Prāgabhāva ends with production; pradhvaṃsābhāva begins with destruction; atyantābhāva is absence in a locus across times; anyonyābhāva is reciprocal non-identity. These must not be collapsed into one undifferentiated "nothing."

11. In “There is no jar on the floor,” what is the pratiyogin?

A. The floor B. The cognition of absence C. The jar D. The perceiver

Answer: C. The jar

Explanation: The pratiyogin is the positive counter-correlate whose absence is asserted; the floor is the locus or anuyogin. Thus every determinate negation has structured content, and “absolute” absence never means relationless nothingness.

12. Which list gives Nyāya’s four means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)?

A. Perception, inference, implication and non-cognition B. Perception, inference, memory and doubt C. Perception, inference, testimony and postulation D. Perception, inference, comparison and testimony

Answer: D. Perception, inference, comparison and testimony

Explanation: Nyāya accepts perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna) and verbal testimony (śabda). It reduces or otherwise handles candidates such as postulation (arthāpatti) and does not count memory as a fresh knowledge-producing means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).

13. In Gautama’s definition, which combination is correct?

A. Avyapadeśya excludes word-dependent cognition; avyabhicāri excludes error; vyavasāyātmaka excludes doubt B. Vyavasāyātmaka means that every valid perception is indeterminate C. All three terms merely repeat sense-object contact D. Avyapadeśya excludes inference; avyabhicāri excludes testimony; vyavasāyātmaka excludes memory

Answer: A. Avyapadeśya excludes word-dependent cognition; avyabhicāri excludes error; vyavasāyātmaka excludes doubt

Explanation: The definition begins with cognition produced by sense-object contact and adds exclusions. Later admission of nirvikalpaka perception creates an interpretive issue around “determinate,” but does not license reversing the clauses.

14. Which statement correctly distinguishes ordinary and extraordinary perception?

A. Ordinary perception reaches universals only; extraordinary perception reaches particulars only B. Ordinary perception uses normal sense/sensory mind (manas) relations; extraordinary perception includes sāmānyalakṣaṇa, jñānalakṣaṇa and yogaja C. Ordinary perception is always verbal; extraordinary perception is always inferential D. Extraordinary perception is rejected by Nyāya

Answer: B. Ordinary perception uses normal sense/sensory mind (manas) relations; extraordinary perception includes sāmānyalakṣaṇa, jñānalakṣaṇa and yogaja

Explanation: Laukika perception proceeds through ordinary contact modes and includes external and internal awareness. Alaukika perception extends the theory through universal-mediated, cognition-mediated and yogically generated access.

15. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa is invoked chiefly to explain

A. how yogic discipline reveals remote objects B. how a word acquires meaning by resemblance C. how perception through a real universal can extend cognition beyond one sensed instance D. how remembered silver is mislocated in shell

Answer: C. how perception through a real universal can extend cognition beyond one sensed instance

Explanation: Because jāti is real, perceiving smokeness or cow-ness can relate the knower to the universal. This supports classification and Nyāya’s account of invariable concomitance (vyāpti), but critics argue that it intellectualizes perception and overreaches finite experience.

16. In the shell-silver illusion, jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa supplies

A. a direct proof that the world is unreal B. the non-existent shell C. yogic awareness of silver atoms D. a cognition-mediated presentation of remembered real silver/silverness

Answer: D. a cognition-mediated presentation of remembered real silver/silverness

Explanation: Present shell-perception revives prior silver-cognition; that cognition mediates the presentation falsely predicated here. The mechanism supports misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) by explaining experiential presence without positing indescribable silver.

17. Yogaja-pratyakṣa is

A. extraordinary perception generated by yogic discipline, said to reach subtle, remote, past or future objects B. inference from disciplined breathing C. ordinary internal perception of pleasure by sensory mind (manas) D. testimony of a trustworthy yogin

Answer: A. extraordinary perception generated by yogic discipline, said to reach subtle, remote, past or future objects

Explanation: Nyāya classifies yogaja as alaukika perception, not verbal testimony (śabda) or inference (anumāna). It is systematically admitted but more contestable than the ordinary core of perception.

18. What is the correct order of the five-member Nyāya syllogism?

A. Pratijñā, udāharaṇa, reason (hetu), nigamana, upanaya B. Pratijñā, reason (hetu), udāharaṇa, upanaya, nigamana C. Reason (hetu), pratijñā, upanaya, udāharaṇa, nigamana D. Udāharaṇa, invariable concomitance (vyāpti), subject of inference (pakṣa), reason (hetu), conclusion

Answer: B. Pratijñā, reason (hetu), udāharaṇa, upanaya, nigamana

Explanation: Parārthanumāna states the thesis, gives the reason, supplies a vyāpti-bearing example, applies it to the subject and concludes. The form makes the inferential warrant communicable to another person.

19. Which best defines an hidden limiting condition (upādhi) in vyāpti-analysis?

A. A counter-reason proving the opposite conclusion B. The subject in which the reason (hetu) occurs C. A condition pervading the property to be proved (sādhya) but not the reason (hetu), making an apparent concomitance conditional D. Any example supporting a universal

Answer: C. A condition pervading the property to be proved (sādhya) but not the reason (hetu), making an apparent concomitance conditional

Explanation: Wet fuel conditions the bad move from fire to smoke: not every fire smokes. Upādhi-nirāsa is therefore central to answering the Cārvāka suspicion that a hidden condition may always generate exceptions.

20. Which is NOT among the five characteristics of a valid reason (hetu)?

A. Pakṣadharmatā B. Abādhitatva C. Sapakṣasattva D. Intrinsic self-luminosity

Answer: D. Intrinsic self-luminosity

Explanation: The five are presence in subject of inference (pakṣa), presence in sapakṣa, absence in vipakṣa, non-contradiction and absence of an equally strong counter-reason. Self-luminosity belongs to a different debate about cognition and validity.

21. A reason (hetu) absent from the subject of inference (pakṣa) is primarily which hetvābhāsa?

A. Asiddha B. Savyabhicāra C. Bādhita D. Satpratipakṣa

Answer: A. Asiddha

Explanation: Asiddha is an unestablished reason; svarūpāsiddha specifically covers absence of the reason (hetu) in the subject. It directly violates pakṣadharmatā.

22. What is the strongest Cārvāka challenge to inference?

A. Inference is valid only in scripture B. Finite observations cannot establish exceptionless invariable concomitance (vyāpti), and unknown upādhis may remain C. All perceptions are verbal D. Every inference has exactly five members

Answer: B. Finite observations cannot establish exceptionless invariable concomitance (vyāpti), and unknown upādhis may remain

Explanation: The challenge attacks the universal bridge from observed to unobserved cases. Nyāya replies through repeated positive/negative observation, search for deviation, removal of adjuncts, hypothetical reasoning (tarka) and

universal realism, while conceding corrigibility in discovery.

23. Comparison (upamāna) yields knowledge when

A. absence is directly perceived B. a hidden effect is inferred from a cause C. a previously described resemblance enables recognition of a word-referent relation D. a Vedic sentence is traced to God

Answer: C. a previously described resemblance enables recognition of a word-referent relation

Explanation: After hearing “a gavaya resembles a cow,” encountering the resembling animal yields knowledge of what “gavaya” denotes. Its distinctive function is semantic acquisition by comparison, not inference from a universal concomitance.

24. Verbal testimony (śabda) is valid, in the central Nyāya formulation, when it is

A. memory of an old sentence B. only an authorless Vedic sentence C. any grammatically complete utterance D. the meaningful statement/advice of a competent and trustworthy āpta

Answer: D. the meaningful statement/advice of a competent and trustworthy āpta

Explanation: An āpta knows and communicates without deceptive intent. Testimony remains an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) because understanding the sentence presents its object, even if reliability may be assessed through other means.

25. Misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) explains illusion as

A. mislocation or false synthesis of real elements B. appearance of an entity neither real nor unreal C. non-apprehension of two valid cognitions only D. apprehension of a wholly non-existent object

Answer: A. mislocation or false synthesis of real elements

Explanation: Nyāya says the “this” and silver are real, but silver existing elsewhere is wrongly predicated of the present shell. This realist account differs from asatkhyāti, akhyāti and Advaita’s anirvacanīya-khyāti.

26. Which inference most directly supports Nyāya’s enduring self?

A. All words signify universals only B. Recognition and memory connect past experience with present ownership in one subject C. The Veda must have an omniscient author D. Atoms require dyadic combination

Answer: B. Recognition and memory connect past experience with present ownership in one subject

Explanation: Nyāya treats cognition, desire, pleasure and effort as qualities requiring a substantive locus. Memory and recognition sharpen the continuity claim; consciousness itself is not the self’s essence.

27. Release (apavarga) in standard Nyāya is primarily

A. eternal enjoyment of sensory pleasure B. isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti) through citta-nirodha C. absolute cessation of pain and the causal chain sustaining rebirth D. identity with Brahman

Answer: C. absolute cessation of pain and the causal chain sustaining rebirth

Explanation: Tattva-jñāna removes false cognition, defects, activity, birth and suffering. The liberated self remains but lacks ordinary cognition and pleasure, producing the familiar “stone-like liberation” objection.

28. Which statement about Nyāya Lord (Īśvara) is correct?

A. God is identical with all selves B. God is unnecessary once atoms are admitted C. God transforms divine substance into the world D. God is the omniscient efficient governor; eternal atoms remain material causes

Answer: D. God is the omniscient efficient governor; eternal atoms remain material causes

Explanation: Nyāya’s God orders atoms, initiates cosmic arrangement and administers karmic fruits. Treating God as upādāna-kāraṇa would import a doctrine foreign to this pluralist atomism.

29. Udayana’s kāryāt argument proceeds from

A. the world’s effect-character to an intelligent maker B. yogic absorption to puruṣa-viśeṣa C. the authorlessness of the Veda to ritual duty D. the self-luminosity of cognition to God

Answer: A. the world's effect-character to an intelligent maker

Explanation: Composite, ordered and dependent wholes are treated as effects analogous to pots. Critics dispute whether the world is an effect in the relevant sense and whether an embodied potter analogy licenses a bodiless cosmic maker.

30. Āyojanāt argues that God is required chiefly to explain

A. why universals are perceived B. the first ordered conjunction and arrangement of inert atoms C. why liberated selves retain cognition D. why words exclude non-referents

Answer: B. the first ordered conjunction and arrangement of inert atoms

Explanation: Atoms and unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) are unconscious; their coordinated initial motion allegedly requires an intelligent impeller. The proof is distinct from kāryāt though both support efficient causality.

31. Dhṛtyādeḥ moves from which explanandum to God?

A. The indeterminacy of initial perception B. The non-identity of pot and cloth C. Cosmic support, maintenance, regulation and dissolution D. The similarity between cow and gavaya

Answer: C. Cosmic support, maintenance, regulation and dissolution

Explanation: The argument expands from origination to continued governance and karmic order. Its vulnerability is the assumption that stable order cannot be brute, natural or explained by non-conscious principles.

32. What is the core of the śruteḥ proof?

A. Only perception can establish God B. Atomic magnitude entails omniscience C. The Veda is invalid unless independently perceived D. Authoritative revelation points to an omniscient source

Answer: D. Authoritative revelation points to an omniscient source

Explanation: Later Nyāya connects Vedic authority to an omniscient āpta. Mīmāṃsā blocks the inference by defending authorlessness, so the proof depends heavily on rival theories of linguistic authority.

33. Which pairing is correct?

A. Padāt-linguistic convention; pratyayataḥ-authoritative cognition/trustworthiness B. Padāt-atomic conjunction; pratyayataḥ-cosmic dissolution C. Padāt-yogic perception; pratyayataḥ-comparison D. Padāt-prior absence; pratyayataḥ-mutual absence

Answer: A. Padāt-linguistic convention; pratyayataḥ-authoritative cognition/trustworthiness

Explanation: These additional Udayana-style routes supplement kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ and śruteḥ. Lists vary across expositions, so one should explain the inferential function rather than merely reproduce labels.

34. How does classical Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) differ most importantly from Nyāya's God?

A. Yoga makes God the material cause of primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. Yoga chiefly presents a special conscious witness (puruṣa), untouched by kleśa and action and moral consequence (karma), serving as teacher and meditative aid C. Yoga denies Lord (Īśvara) altogether D. Yoga proves God solely from atom-combination

Answer: B. Yoga chiefly presents a special conscious witness (puruṣa), untouched by kleśa and action and moral consequence (karma), serving as teacher and meditative aid

Explanation: Both admit Lord (Īśvara), but not for identical systematic work. Nyāya develops natural-theological proofs for a cosmic efficient governor; Yoga foregrounds puruṣa-viśeṣa and Īśvara-praṇidhāna in soteriology.

35. Non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)/new production (ārambhavāda) means that

A. cause and effect are absolutely unrelated B. production is only an illusion of language C. the effect as effect is newly produced rather than already actual in the cause D. the effect eternally exists in the cause but is concealed

Answer: C. the effect as effect is newly produced rather than already actual in the cause

Explanation: Nyāya does not teach ex nihilo creation. Determinate material, non-inherent and efficient conditions possess causal capacity, but production terminates the effect's prior absence and begins a new whole.

36. An anyathāsiddha antecedent is

A. the relation of whole to parts B. an antecedent whose priority or feature is otherwise explained and causally irrelevant to the effect C. the indispensable material cause D. the posterior absence of a destroyed effect

Answer: D. the posterior absence of a destroyed effect

Explanation: The potter's father and the colour of a causal stick may precede the pot without entering the relevant causal set. Ananyathāsiddha antecedence, by contrast, marks indispensable causal relevance.

37. How does the seed-tree example support Nyāya causation?

A. The tree has prāgabhāva before production; the seed has capacity but does not contain an already actual tree B. The tree arises without material conditions C. The tree and seed are numerically identical D. The tree is absolutely impossible before it appears

Answer: A. The tree has prāgabhāva before production; the seed has capacity but does not contain an already actual tree

Explanation: Prior absence is beginningless and ends when the effect arises. Nyāya uses it against Sāṃkhya latency while distinguishing producible non-existence from an impossibility such as a hare's horn.

38. Which account matches Vaiśeṣika atomism?

A. Atoms are perceptible, divisible and produced B. Eternal partless element-specific atoms combine into dyads and larger compounds; God/unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) explains first motion C. Only one qualityless atom becomes all substances D. Atoms are momentary ideas in consciousness

Answer: B. Eternal partless element-specific atoms combine into dyads and larger compounds; God/unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) explains first motion

Explanation: Earth, water, fire and air atoms persist through dissolution and form gross objects through combination. Lord (Īśvara) is not their material source; he is invoked as intelligent initiator and governor of arrangement.

39. In the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)-pramāṇaphala debate, the central contrast is that

A. both regard memory as the only means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) B. both identify means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) with an eternal self C. Nyāya distinguishes operative means from resulting valid cognition, while Buddhist epistemology tightens or identifies act and result within cognition D. Nyāya denies results while Buddhism denies instruments

Answer: C. Nyāya distinguishes operative means from resulting valid cognition, while Buddhist epistemology tightens or identifies act and result within cognition

Explanation: Nyāya's distinction belongs to its causal realism: instrument and fruit perform different roles. Buddhist epistemology treats a cognition's object-manifestation and successful functioning without positing the same substantial apparatus.

40. Which answer-writing move best satisfies the directive "critically discuss" in a Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika question?

A. List definitions only B. Compare with Western philosophy before explaining the Indian doctrine C. Give only objections because "critical" means rejection D. Explain the doctrine and argument, present the strongest objection and reply, assess residual force, then give a graded verdict

Answer: D. Explain the doctrine and argument, present the strongest objection and reply, assess residual force, then give a graded verdict

Explanation: Directive fidelity requires exposition plus evaluation. A balanced verdict should follow, not replace, accurate doctrine; "critical" never licenses ignoring the school's own reasons or declaring a simplistic yes/no conclusion.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

41. Why is ayutasiddhatva not, by itself, a sufficient definition of inherence (samavāya)?

A. Because practical or other inseparability does not establish the specified constitutive inherence relation B. Because inherence (samavāya) relates only two atoms in contact C. Because every conjunction is eternal D. Because qualities exist independently of all substances

Answer: A. Because practical or other inseparability does not establish the specified constitutive inherence relation

Explanation: Ayutasiddhatva is a necessary diagnostic for the standard relation, but inherence (samavāya) also requires their distinctive ontological dependence and non-conjunctive structure. Mere inability to separate two objects physically is insufficient.

42. Which classification is correct?

A. "Air lacks heat" is prāgabdhāva; "air is not fire" is pradhvaṃsābhāva B. "Air lacks heat" is atyantābhāva; "air is not fire" is anyonyābhāva C. Both are anyonyābhāva D. Both are atyantābhāva

Answer: B. "Air lacks heat" is atyantābhāva; "air is not fire" is anyonyābhāva

Explanation: The first denies a quality in a locus across the relevant times; the second denies identity between two substances. Neither is prior absence, because no production-event is being described.

43. Which claim about the Nyāya self is false?

A. It persists in liberation even when ordinary cognition ceases B. It is distinct from body, senses and sensory mind (manas) C. Consciousness is its eternally manifest essence D. It is the locus of cognition, desire, pleasure and pain

Answer: C. Consciousness is its eternally manifest essence

Explanation: Nyāya makes consciousness an adventitious quality (guṇa), unlike Advaita. This permits deep sleep and liberated existence without manifest cognition, though it invites the objection that the resulting self is empty or stone-like.

44. Which statement is a serious factual error in an answer on Nyāya theism?

A. Atoms provide material causality B. God administers karmic fruits C. God is the intelligent efficient cause D. God is the material stuff transformed into every physical object

Answer: D. God is the material stuff transformed into every physical object

Explanation: Nyāya remains a pluralist realist atomism: Lord (Īśvara) is nimitta-kāraṇa, not upādāna-kāraṇa. Confusing these roles collapses its distinction from several Vedāntic accounts.

45. Which pairing of extraordinary perception and function is accurate?

A. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-universal-mediated access; jñānalakṣaṇa-prior-cognition-mediated presentation; yogaja-yogically generated access B. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-verbal testimony; jñānalakṣaṇa-inference; yogaja-memory C. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-absence only; jñānalakṣaṇa-God-proof; yogaja-comparison D. All three are ordinary sense-object conjunction

Answer: A. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-universal-mediated access; jñānalakṣaṇa-prior-cognition-mediated presentation; yogaja-yogically generated access

Explanation: The three forms do different explanatory work and should not be used interchangeably. Universal perception supports classification/invariable concomitance (vyāpti); cognition-mediated perception supports cross-modal presentation and error; yogaja extends access through discipline.

46. Which mapping from hetu-defect to positive condition is correct?

A. Satpratipakṣa violates sapakṣasattva only; savyabhicāra violates no condition B. Asiddha violates pakṣadharmatā; bādhita violates abādhitatva C. Viruddha is simply absence of testimony D. Bādhita violates pakṣadharmatā; asiddha violates abādhitatva

Answer: B. Asiddha violates pakṣadharmatā; bādhita violates abādhitatva

Explanation: An unestablished reason fails presence in the subject; a stultified conclusion is defeated by stronger knowledge. Satpratipakṣa violates non-opposition, while irregular and contradictory reasons expose defective invariable concomitance (vyāpti).

47. Which is the best coordinated causal account of a cloth?

A. The weaver alone is cause because material is passive B. Threads are nimitta; weaving is samavāyi; colour is the fourth independent cause C. Threads are samavāyi, their relevant conjunction asamavāyi, and the weaver/instruments nimitta D. Every earlier event is equally a cause

Answer: C. Threads are samavāyi, their relevant conjunction asamavāyi, and the weaver/instruments nimitta

Explanation: Nyāya differentiates material inherence, relevant qualities/relations in that material and efficient production. The ananyathāsiddha test prevents the causal set from expanding to every antecedent.

48. A high-quality response to a printed PYQ should first

A. silently rewrite the question into a preferred topic B. treat every directive as “describe” C. answer a nearby doctrine that has more notes D. preserve the printed wording, decode each demand and allocate answer-space proportionately to marks

Answer: D. preserve the printed wording, decode each demand and allocate answer-space proportionately to marks

Explanation: Corpus control protects exact year, subpart, wording and marks. Demand decoding prevents a response from omitting comparison, justification or criticism, while proportional depth distinguishes 10-, 15- and 20-mark models.

REVIEW-PROMOTED CATEGORY AND SOURCE-CONTROL MCQS

49. Which statement correctly distinguishes the two category systems?

A. Nyāya's sixteen are topics of inquiry, proof and debate; Vaiśeṣika's seven are ontological categories, and the latter fall within Nyāya's broad field of knowable objects without losing distinct ownership. B. Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika each begin with the same seven ontological categories and differ only in spelling. C. Vaiśeṣika has sixteen debate categories, while Nyāya has seven kinds of atom. D. Both lists are merely alternative enumerations of the four means of valid knowledge.

Answer: A. Nyāya's sixteen are topics of inquiry, proof and debate; Vaiśeṣika's seven are ontological categories, and the latter fall within Nyāya's broad field of knowable objects without losing distinct ownership.

Explanation: Nyāya's list organizes rational inquiry and soteriological knowables; Vaiśeṣika classifies kinds of being. Their later synthesis does not erase this difference.

50. Which comparison of the schools' means of valid knowledge is accurate?

A. Both classical schools accept only testimony. B. Nyāya accepts perception, inference, comparison and testimony; classical Vaiśeṣika accepts perception and inference and reduces the other two. C. Vaiśeṣika accepts six means, while Nyāya accepts one. D. The later synthesis rejects inference because it adopts atomism.

Answer: B. Nyāya accepts perception, inference, comparison and testimony; classical Vaiśeṣika accepts perception and inference and reduces the other two.

Explanation: The fourfold list is specifically Nyāya's classical epistemology. The combined system commonly uses it, but ownership must remain visible.

51. Which set correctly presents Nyāya inference classifications?

A. Substance, quality and motion; prior, posterior and mutual absence; secular and Vedic. B. Perception, inference and testimony; thesis, doubt and defeat; dyad, triad and atom. C. Inference for oneself/another; cause-to-effect, effect-to-cause and non-causal uniformity; positive-only, negative-only and positive-negative concomitance. D. Valid, invalid and indescribable; direct, imagined and empty; eternal, momentary and neither.

Answer: C. Inference for oneself/another; cause-to-effect, effect-to-cause and non-causal uniformity; positive-only, negative-only and positive-negative concomitance.

Explanation: The three grids classify purpose, direction or basis of uniformity, and form of concomitance. They supplement the five-member proof and fallacy tests.

52. How does Nyāya explain knowledge that no jar is on the table?

A. By a self-luminous cognition unrelated to any locus. B. By accepting Bhāṭṭa non-cognition as a fifth independent means of knowledge. C. By treating absence as an absolutely contentless void. D. By apprehending the table as locus qualified by jar-absence under adequate conditions, using perception or inference rather than a separate non-cognition means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).

Answer: D. By apprehending the table as locus qualified by jar-absence under adequate conditions, using perception or inference rather than a separate non-cognition means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).

Explanation: The table is the locus and jar the counterpositive. Buddhism avoids reifying absence; Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā separately owns non-cognition as an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).

53. Which four conditions make a sentence intelligible in Nyāya testimony?

A. Mutual expectancy, semantic fitness, proximity and intended meaning. B. Conjunction, inherence, particularity and absence. C. Doubt, wrangling, quibble and defeat. D. Cause, effect, motion and atom.

Answer: A. Mutual expectancy, semantic fitness, proximity and intended meaning.

Explanation: Expectancy (ākāṅkṣā), fitness (yogyatā), proximity (sannidhi/āsatti) and intended meaning (tātparya) explain sentence comprehension in addition to speaker reliability.

54. Which sequence gives Gautama's six canonical marks of the self?

A. Memory, recognition, body, senses, mind and rebirth. B. Desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain and cognition. C. Earth, water, fire, air, ether and time. D. Attachment, action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth, pain, knowledge and release.

Answer: B. Desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain and cognition.

Explanation: Memory, recognition and instrumentality are supplementary self-arguments. They must not replace the six marks when the PYQ asks for the six reasons.

55. Which statement accurately describes Vaiśeṣika atomic combination?

A. One atom becomes perceptible without combination. B. Three atoms directly form the first perceptible triad. C. Two atoms form an imperceptible dyad, and three dyads form a perceptible triad. D. God creates atoms from nothing before every cosmic cycle.

Answer: C. Two atoms form an imperceptible dyad, and three dyads form a perceptible triad.

Explanation: Atoms and dyads are imperceptible; the triad is the textbook threshold of perceptibility. God is efficient cause in the later synthesis, not material creator of eternal atoms.

56. Why should Nyāya and Yoga not be said to prove God identically?

A. Yoga rejects every use of the term Lord (īśvara). B. Nyāya treats God as material cause, while Yoga treats God as atoms. C. Both merely quote the same Vedic sentence and make no further claim. D. Nyāya infers an efficient cause, atomic arranger and karmic governor, whereas classical Yoga foregrounds a special conscious witness and meditative support rather than Udayana's cumulative creator proof.

Answer: D. Nyāya infers an efficient cause, atomic arranger and karmic governor, whereas classical Yoga foregrounds a special conscious witness and meditative support rather than Udayana's cumulative creator proof.

Explanation: Both admit Lord (īśvara), but their argument, cosmological role and soteriological function differ. Later Yoga commentaries may strengthen theism without erasing the classical distinction.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 22 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Vaiśeṣika philosophers explain the difference of the relationships in the two cases-(i) the brown colour of the table and (ii) the book on the table? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Distinguish saṃyoga from inherence (samavāya), apply each relation to the printed examples, and explain why Vaiśeṣika cannot reduce one to the other.

Independent model answer:

The brown colour and table stand in **inherence (samavāya)**; the book and table stand in **samyoga**.

Inherence (samavāya) is eternal, intimate inherence between inseparably related entities: quality and substance, action and substance, universal and particular, whole and parts, or viśeṣa and eternal substance. Brownness cannot exist independently and then be placed on the table; it inheres in its locus.

Samyoga is conjunction between independently existing substances. The book and table can exist apart, their relation is produced and destructible, and either relatum may move away.

Test	Brown-table	Book-table
Relation	inherence (samavāya)	samyoga
Relata	quality-substance	substance-substance
Separability	ayutasiddha	yutasiddha
Duration	relation treated as eternal	produced and destructible

Verdict: Vaisesika needs inherence (samavāya) because conjunction cannot explain the constitutive unity of dependent qualities with substances.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Names inherence (samavāya) for colour-table and saṃyoga for book-table.
- Defines the relations through ontological dependence, not mere physical closeness.
- Uses yutasiddha/ayutasiddha and production-destruction tests.
- Explains why inherence (samavāya) is sui generis rather than mere inseparability.
- Ends with the philosophical payoff of the distinction.

2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail.

Demand decoding: Compare the ontology and cognition of absence in Buddhist and Nyāya accounts; identify locus and counterpositive and assess the cost of reifying absence.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya-Vaisesika treats **absence (abhāva)** as a real category. When a competent perceiver apprehends the table under suitable conditions and no jar is present, the non-existence of the jar is directly known. The table is the locus; jar is the **pratiyogin**, the counterpositive whose absence is qualified.

Buddhist analysis avoids a separately existing negative entity. Absence-cognition is explained through the positive perception of the bare locus together with conceptual exclusion, non-apprehension, or inference from failure to perceive an otherwise perceptible jar.

Nyaya argues that the cognition has a determinate object-jar-absence-and cannot be reduced to mere table-perception, because "the table is jarless" differs from simply "this is a table." The Buddhist replies that reifying every meaningful negation needlessly multiplies entities.

Verdict: Nyaya offers ontological realism about absence; Buddhism offers an economical epistemic-conceptual analysis. Nyaya better preserves the intentional object of negative judgement but pays a higher ontological cost.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Presents both schools rather than giving a one-sided account.
- Identifies the table as locus and jar as counterpositive.
- Explains Nyāya realism about absence (abhāva) and the Buddhist reduction.
- Uses the difference between bare-locus cognition and qualified absence-cognition.
- Offers a balanced economy-versus-intentional-object verdict.

2018 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How do the Naiyāyikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding: Explain Nyāya's proof-family, compare its method and divine functions with Yoga, and explicitly decide whether the two prove God in the same way.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya infers Lord (Īśvara) as an omniscient, eternal and disembodied efficient cause who arranges eternal atoms, dispenses karmic fruits and grounds authoritative Vedic testimony. The world is an effect composed of parts and exhibiting order; like a pot, it requires an intelligent maker. Atomic conjunction also requires direction, and moral results require an omniscient governor.

The main Nyaya routes are:

karyat -> world as effect implies maker
ayojanat -> atomic arrangement implies arranger
dhrtyadeh -> support and order imply governor
padat -> word-meaning convention implies author
pratyayatah-> Vedic trustworthiness implies omniscient source
sruteh -> scripture testifies to God

Yoga accepts **Lord (Īśvara)**, but its emphasis differs. Patanjali defines Lord (Īśvara) as a special conscious witness (puruṣa) untouched by afflictions, actions, fruits and latent deposits. Lord (Īśvara) is the unsurpassed teacher and an aid to samadhi through Isvara-pranidhana. Classical Yoga does not require Lord (Īśvara) as the material cause and does not develop the same cumulative cosmological-natural-theological proof structure as Udayana.

Nyaya's God coordinates atoms and action and moral consequence (karma); Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) is primarily a unique spiritual exemplar and meditative support. Later commentators may strengthen Yoga theism, but the doctrinal functions remain distinct.

Objections arise from Samkhya, which sees unconscious primordial material nature (prakṛti) as sufficient; Mimamsa, which regards the Veda as authorless; and the problem of evil. Nyaya replies that atoms and unseen causal force (adṛṣṭa) lack intelligence, authorless sentences cannot establish purposive convention, and God allocates rather than authors karmic desert.

Verdict: Both admit Lord (Īśvara), but not by the same route or for the same systematic task. Nyaya offers inferential natural theology; Yoga integrates a special conscious witness (puruṣa) into soteriological discipline.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2018 · Q6(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Covers multiple Nyāya arguments and their common inferential structure.
- Keeps God an efficient, not material, cause.
- Defines Yoga Lord (Īśvara) as puruṣa-viśeṣa and a soteriological aid.
- Answers the same-way question with reasons, not assertion.
- Includes objections, replies and a qualified comparative verdict.

2019 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Justify the status of Absence (abhāva) as a category in Vaiśeṣika philosophy.

Demand decoding: Justify, rather than merely enumerate, absence (abhāva) by showing the irreducibility, structure and explanatory role of negative cognition.

Independent model answer:

Absence (abhāva) is admitted because negative cognitions are objective and irreducible. "There is no jar on the floor" is not merely cognition of the floor; it presents the floor as qualified by jar-absence.

The four forms are:

Absence (abhāva)	Meaning
Pragabhava	prior absence before production
Pradhvamsabhava	posterior absence after destruction
Atyantabhava	absolute absence between incompatible entities
Anyonyabhava	mutual absence or difference

Every absence has a locus and counterpositive. This prevents "nothing" from becoming an independent void.

Absence (abhāva) is nameable, knowable and explanatorily necessary, so it satisfies the broad category (padārtha) criterion.

Critics object that absence is only failure to perceive. Nyaya replies that non-apprehension under adequate conditions yields a positive, determinate judgement about what is absent and where.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2019 · Q5(a) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Explains why cognition of a qualified absence exceeds bare locus-perception.
- Classifies all four abhāvas accurately.
- Uses locus and counterpositive to prevent "nothing" becoming featureless.
- Answers the reduction-to-non-apprehension objection.

- Connects knowability and nameability with padārtha-status.

2019 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: What is the role of Jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa in explaining Misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti)?

Demand decoding: Relate the extraordinary-perception mechanism to Nyāya's realist theory of error, tracing the shell-silver cognition and testing whether the mechanism is adequate.

Independent model answer:

Misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) explains illusion as mislocation of a real property: in "this is silver," the presented shell is perceived here, while real silver remembered from elsewhere supplies silverness. Error joins two real elements in a false relation.

Jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa is extraordinary perception in which prior cognition functions as a special mediator. The present shell triggers memory of silver; through cognition-mediated contact, silverness is presented as belonging to the shell.

```
visual contact with shell
    ↓
revival of prior silver-cognition
    ↓
cognition-mediated presentation of silverness
    ↓
"this shell is silver"
```

It explains why illusion feels perceptual rather than like detached memory. The defect lies not in the existence of the relata but in their predicative synthesis.

Advaita objects that absent silver cannot be perceptually related to the present locus; Yogacara questions the external realist framework. Nyaya replies that extraordinary contact is required precisely to explain cross-locational presentation without inventing an indescribable object.

Verdict: Jñānalakṣaṇa is the epistemic mechanism that makes misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) a realist error theory, though critics may see it as an ad hoc extension of perception.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2019 · Q6(b) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Separates misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) as theory from jñānalakṣaṇa as mechanism.
- Traces present perception, memory revival and false synthesis.
- Preserves the reality of both shell and silver while locating the error in predication.
- Explains why illusion feels presentational rather than merely memorial.
- Includes Advaita/Yogācāra pressure and a reasoned verdict.

2019 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: How does Udayana prove the existence of God through Kāryāt, Āyojanāt, Dhṛtyādeḥ and Śruteḥ? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Expound each named proof in its own inferential logic, disclose its assumptions, confront major objections, and judge the cumulative case.

Independent model answer:

Udayana's proofs form a cumulative explanation of production, arrangement, stability and authoritative revelation.

Kāryat: The world is an effect because it is composite, mutable and dependent. Effects such as pots require intelligent makers; therefore the world requires an omniscient maker. God is efficient, not material, cause because eternal atoms supply material.

Ayojanat: Atoms are inert and unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) is non-conscious. Their purposive initial conjunction into dyads and complex bodies requires intelligent direction.

Dhr̥tyadeh: The world's continued support, coordinated order and dissolution require a governor. Natural regularity and the allocation of karmic fruits are not explained by blind matter alone.

Sruteh: Scripture testifies to God. Nyaya supplements this with the argument that reliable Vedic discourse requires an omniscient source; sentencehood and authority are difficult to ground in an authorless text.

The proofs presuppose that order is explanatory evidence of intelligence, unconscious causes cannot organize themselves teleologically, and testimony ultimately depends on a trustworthy speaker.

Samkhya argues that primordial material nature (prakṛti) suffices; Mimamsa defends an authorless Veda; Buddhists reject permanent creator and atoms. Nyaya replies that unconscious primordial material nature (prakṛti) or unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) cannot select morally fitted outcomes, while an omniscient governor coordinates pre-existing materials and karmic law.

The problem of evil remains: if God is omnipotent and benevolent, suffering is difficult. Nyaya treats God as impartial administrator of beginningless action and moral consequence (karma), though the critic may ask why such a system is sustained.

Verdict: Udayana is strongest when read cumulatively: no single analogy demonstrates God, but maker, arranger, sustainer and authoritative speaker jointly form Nyaya's best explanation.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2019 · Q7(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Explains all four proofs individually and accurately.
- Keeps atoms as material cause and Lord (Īśvara) as intelligent efficient cause.
- Makes the cumulative structure explicit.
- Engages Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and evil objections.
- Gives replies without pretending that residual difficulties disappear.
- Ends with a graded rather than dogmatic verdict.

2020 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the concepts of 'Anyathāsiddha' and 'Ananyathāsiddha' in the context of Non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda).

Demand decoding: Define both causal filters, show why mere antecedence is insufficient, and connect them to new production and the threefold causal scheme.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya defines a cause as an **ananyathāsiddha** antecedent: an indispensable prior condition whose relevance to the effect cannot be explained otherwise. Mere temporal priority is insufficient, because countless earlier events are causally irrelevant.

An **anyathāsiddha** antecedent is otherwise established or irrelevant to production. The potter's father precedes the pot but is not its cause; the colour of the stick used in making a pot is incidental to its productive role.

The distinction disciplines **non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)**, according to which the effect is a new beginning. A pot does not pre-exist in clay, yet its production is not ex nihilo: clay, conjunction, potter and instruments are causally necessary in distinct ways.

Nyaya distinguishes:

Cause	Example in pot
Samavayi	clay/parts inhering in effect
Asamavayi	conjunction or qualities inhering in material cause
Nimitta	potter, wheel and instruments

Only relevant indispensable antecedents enter the causal set. Critics ask whether indispensability is discovered without already knowing causal laws. Nyaya answers through repeated observation, elimination of conditions and explanatory analysis.

Verdict: The pair prevents new production (ārambhavāda) from collapsing into the claim that every antecedent causes every later event.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2020 · Q6(c) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines ananyathāsiddha as indispensable relevant antecedence.
- Explains anyathāsiddha through causally incidental antecedents.
- Links the distinction directly to non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)/new production (ārambhavāda).
- Uses the three Nyāya cause-types and concrete examples.
- Shows how the distinction prevents causal over-inclusion.

2020 · Q8(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the logical and metaphysical status of Viśeṣa in the context of Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoding: Explain viśeṣa's individuating role, its metaphysical location and logical necessity, then test regress and ontological-economy objections.

Independent model answer:

Viśeṣa is ultimate particularity, admitted to distinguish numerically different eternal substances that share all general properties: atoms of one element, selves, minds, time, space and ether. Compound objects differ through parts and qualities; indiscernible eternal simples require a primitive differentiator.

Logically, viśeṣa grounds numerical distinction where qualitative criteria fail. Metaphysically, it is eternal, innumerable, resident by inherence (samavāya) in eternal substances, and self-differentiating.

The main objection is regress: if viśeṣa differentiates atoms, what differentiates one viśeṣa from another? Vaiśeṣika replies that viśeṣas are **svato-vyavrtta**, self-excluding; demanding another differentiator misunderstands their primitive function.

A second objection calls viśeṣa an ontological IOU—an imperceptible entity postulated only to save plurality. The realist reply is abductive: if multiple eternal reals are required by causal and moral explanation, a principle of individuation is unavoidable.

Verdict: Viśeṣa is logically intelligible as primitive thisness, but its metaphysical force depends on prior commitment to plural eternal substances. It completes the system more than it independently proves itself.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2020 · Q8(b) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- States exactly which eternal substances host *viśeṣa*.
- Explains numerical distinction where qualitative distinction fails.
- Addresses the regress through *svato-vyāvartaka*.
- Does not treat the reply as cost-free.
- Shows that *viśeṣa* depends on prior plural-realist commitments.

2021 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoding: Use the seed-tree case to explain non-existence of the effect before production (*asatkāryavāda*), distinguish causal capacity from latent actual effect, and answer the Sāṃkhya objection.

Independent model answer:

No. Nyaya-Vaisesika defends **non-existence of the effect before production (*asatkāryavāda*)**: the effect does not pre-exist as an actual effect in its material cause. The tree is a new product, although its production depends on seed-material, water, soil, heat and other conditions.

If the tree already existed in the seed, production would be redundant; the distinction between cause and effect would collapse; and the same effect should be available without the complete causal complex. The seed possesses capacity, not a concealed tree.

The relation is explained through prior absence:

pragabhava of tree + complete causal conditions
↓
new production of tree
↓
destruction may yield *pradhvamsabhava*

Sāṃkhya objects that what is absolutely non-existent cannot arise. Nyaya replies that "non-existent before production" means prior absence in the cause, not impossibility like a hare's horn.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2021 · Q5(a) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Answers the question immediately in the Nyāya sense.
- Distinguishes prior absence from absolute impossibility.
- Connects *prāgabdhāva* with production.
- Explains the indispensable causal complex.
- Contrasts capacity with concealed pre-existence.

2021 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: Explain with reference to Nyāya Philosophy, the nature of verbal testimony (*śabda*) as the advice of *āpta* (a reliable person).

Demand decoding: Define *āpta* and verbal testimony (*śabda*), state the conditions of valid sentence-cognition, and justify testimony as an independent means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*).

Independent model answer:

Verbal testimony (śabda) is valid verbal testimony, classically defined as the statement or instruction of an **apta**-a competent and trustworthy speaker who knows the fact and communicates it without intention to deceive.

Its validity requires:

1. a reliable speaker;
2. meaningful words governed by convention;
3. syntactic expectancy, compatibility and proximity;
4. a hearer who understands the sentence;
5. absence of defeating conditions.

Testimony is independent because much knowledge-history, distant places, specialized science and ordinary social facts-cannot be reconstructed by each hearer through direct perception or inference. The hearer may infer the speaker's reliability, but sentence-understanding yields its object through linguistic cognition.

Vedic testimony is treated as supremely reliable through divine or omniscient authorship in Nyaya. Mimamsa instead grounds Vedic authority in authorlessness.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2021 · Q5(b) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines āpta through competence, truth-knowledge and honest communication.
- Lists semantic and hearer-side conditions.
- Explains why dependence on speaker reliability does not reduce verbal testimony (śabda) to inference.
- Uses ordinary and Vedic testimony carefully.
- Adds the Nyāya-Mīmāṃsā contrast without losing focus.

2021 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Question: Is 'inseparability' (ayuta-siddhatva) a necessary condition or a sufficient condition for defining characteristics (lakṣaṇa) of inherence (samavāya)? Explain with reference to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoding: Decide whether ayutasiddhatva is necessary and/or sufficient, support the decision with standard inherence (samavāya) pairs, and exclude counterexamples.

Independent model answer:

Ayutasiddhatva means inseparability: one relatum cannot exist independently in the relevant way from the other. It is necessary for inherence (samavāya) because inherence connects whole-parts, quality-substance, action-substance, universal-instance and visesa-eternal substance.

It is not by itself sufficient. Mere inseparability can arise from other facts, and inherence (samavāya) requires a distinctive constitutive relation between ontologically dependent relata. The relation must also be non-conjunctive, intimate and not produced like samyoga.

For example, colour cannot exist without some substance, and this supports inherence. But two tightly joined physical objects may be practically inseparable while remaining connected only by conjunction.

The regress objection asks whether inherence (samavāya) needs another relation to connect it to its relata. Vaisesika stops the regress by treating inherence (samavāya) as self-linking and sui generis.

Verdict: Ayutasiddhatva is a necessary diagnostic but not a complete sufficient definition unless supplemented by the specific locus-relatum structure of inherence.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2021 · Q5(c) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Directly answers: necessary but not independently sufficient.
- Defines ontological inseparability rather than practical non-separation.
- Uses standard inference pairs and a conjunction counterexample.
- Explains the additional constitutive relation required.
- Handles relation-regress through the system's sui-generis stopping point.

2022 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: What is the ontological status of Sāmānya, according to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy? Critically examine.

Demand decoding: State sāmānya's complete realist profile and critically assess its explanatory value against Buddhist exclusion and the one-in-many difficulty.

Independent model answer:

Samanya is a real, eternal universal, one in many, inhering in substances, qualities or actions. Cow-ness is not merely a word or mental image; it objectively grounds common predication and classification across individual cows.

Universals form higher and lower orders: *satta* or being is maximally general, while cow-ness is restricted. Samanya is related to instances by inherence (*samavāya*).

Buddhist apoha theory objects that commonness can be explained by exclusion of non-cows without a universal. A further problem asks how one entity is wholly present in many places. Vaisesika replies that a universal is non-spatially one and multiply instantiated, not physically divided.

The six jati-badhakas restrict indiscriminate multiplication of universals, showing that Vaisesika realism is disciplined rather than unlimited.

Verdict: Samanya gives a robust basis for classification and inference, but its independent reality is less economical than nominalist or exclusion accounts.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2022 · Q5(b) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Describes the universal as real, eternal and one-in-many.
- Locates it in instances through inherence (*samavāya*).
- Explains classification and predication rather than merely naming cow-ness.
- Uses jāti-bādhakas to show disciplined realism.
- Balances explanatory robustness against nominalist economy.

2022 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: How do Naiyāyikas respond to Cārvāka's objections against inference (*anumāna*) and establish inference as an independent means of knowledge? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct Cārvāka's invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) challenge, give Nyāya's multi-stage reply, establish independence, and assess the residual induction problem.

Independent model answer:

Carvaka argues that inference depends on **invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**, universal concomitance, which cannot be known. Perception covers only finite cases; inference used to establish invariable concomitance (vyāpti) becomes circular; and hidden conditions may produce exceptions.

Nyaya replies that invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is not an a priori leap. It is secured through repeated agreement in presence and absence, absence of counter-instance, elimination of **hidden limiting condition (upādhi)**, and **hypothetical reasoning (tarka)**:

bhuyodarsana + vyabhicara-adarsana
+ upadhi-nirasa + hypothetical reasoning (tarka)
↓
qualified grasp of invariable concomitance (vyāpti)
↓
reflective inferential cognition (parāmarśa)
↓
inferential cognition

Inference is indispensable even to Carvaka criticism. To claim that unobserved cases may differ is itself an inferential generalization. Everyday action-fire from smoke, danger from signs, another mind from behaviour-also presupposes reliable transition beyond perception.

Nyaya does not claim infallible induction from a small sample. Invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is fallible in discovery but corrigible through counterexamples and condition-analysis. Once correctly known and applied through pakṣa-dharmata and reflective inferential cognition (parāmarśa), it produces new knowledge.

Verdict: Nyaya defeats global scepticism about inference, though its account of universal necessity remains vulnerable to the Humean problem that observed regularity does not logically compel all unobserved cases.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2022 · Q7(c) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- States finite-observation, circularity and hidden-upādhi objections.
- Explains agreement in presence (anvaya)-agreement in absence (vyatireka), counterexample-search, upādhi-nirāsa and hypothetical reasoning (tarka).
- Uses pakṣadharmatā and reflective inferential cognition (parāmarśa) to complete inference.
- Exposes the practical/self-referential cost of global rejection.
- Concedes the Humean residue while defeating total scepticism.

2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Present an account of Vaiśeṣika's view of negation in the light of their statement - "Negation always has a counterpositive and absolute negation is an impossibility."

Demand decoding: Explain the relational structure of every negation, clarify the apparent tension with atyantābhāva, and relate the thesis to the four absences.

Independent model answer:

An absence is always the absence **of something** in a locus. The absent entity is the **pratiyogin** or counterpositive; the place where it is absent is the **anuyogin** or locus. "There is no jar on the floor" means jar-absence qualified by the floor.

Absolute featureless nothing cannot be cognized, named or distinguished. Even **atyantabhava**, often translated absolute absence, remains relational: colour is absent from air at all times, or a hare's horn is absent as a possible entity, relative to a specified counterpositive.

Mutual absence explains difference: a pot is not cloth and cloth is not pot. Prior and posterior absences explain before-production and after-destruction.

Verdict: Vaisesika negation is relationally realist, not commitment to an independent Nothing. Its strength is logical determinacy; its cost is treating negative facts as ontological entities.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines pratiyogin and locus/anuyogin.
- Shows why featureless nothing is neither nameable nor cognizable.
- Clarifies that atyantābhāva is still counterpositive-relative.
- Connects mutual, prior and posterior absence to the thesis.
- Evaluates determinacy against ontological cost.

2023 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question: Elucidate Naiyāyikas view of ordinary and extraordinary perception. Are they justified in accepting that universals are perceived? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Classify laukika and alaukika perception, explain all extraordinary forms, then argue for and against perceptual access to universals.

Independent model answer:

Ordinary perception (**laukika**) arises through normal sense-object contact and includes external perception through five senses and internal perception through sensory mind (manas). Nyaya analyses six modes of contact, such as conjunction, inherence in the conjoined, and inherence of a universal in a quality.

Extraordinary perception (**alaukika**) has three forms:

1. **Samanyalaksana:** perception of many or all instances through a perceived universal.
2. **Jñanalaksana:** prior cognition mediates presentation, as in seeing fragrant sandalwood or illusory silver.
3. **Yogaja:** extraordinary perception generated by yogic discipline.

Nyaya justifies universal-perception by arguing that recognition "this is a cow" includes direct awareness of cow-ness; otherwise classification and invariable concomitance (vyāpti) would lack objective grounding. Samanyalaksana also helps explain knowledge extending beyond presently sensed particulars.

Buddhists object that perception is of unique particulars and universals are conceptual constructions. The Nyaya account risks making perception too intellectual and overextending it to unobserved members.

Verdict: Ordinary perception is plausible realism; samanyalaksana is systematically useful but the least secure form because it blurs perception and conceptual generalization.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2023 · Q6(c) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Gives external/internal ordinary perception and the contact framework.
- Explains sāmānyalakṣaṇa, jñānalakṣaṇa and yogaja distinctly.
- Connects universal perception with recognition and invariable concomitance (vyāpti).
- Presents the Buddhist particularist objection.

- Offers a discriminating verdict rather than accepting all perception-types equally.

2023 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: Elucidate Naiyāyikas account of fallacies of the middle term in relation to five characteristics of valid middle term.

Demand decoding: State the five marks of a valid reason (hetu), explain the major hetvābhāsas, and map each defect to the relevant failed condition and invariable concomitance (vyāpti).

Independent model answer:

A valid **reason (hetu)** must satisfy five marks:

1. **Paksadharmata:** present in the subject.
2. **Sapakasasattva:** present in positive instances where the probandum occurs.
3. **Vipakasasattvabhava:** absent in negative instances.
4. **Abadhitatva:** not contradicted by stronger knowledge.
5. **Asatpratipaksatva:** not opposed by an equally strong counter-reason.

Hetvābhāsas arise when these conditions fail:

Fallacy	Defect	Illustration
Savyabhicara	irregular reason; fails concomitance	hill has fire because knowable
Viruddha	reason proves opposite	sound is eternal because produced
Satpratipaksa	counterbalanced reason	opposing valid-looking reason (hetu)
Asiddha	reason unestablished in subject of inference (pakṣa)	sky-lotus is fragrant because lotus
Badhita	contradicted by stronger cognition	fire is cold because substance

Some classifications align subtypes differently, but the logical core is failure of subject-presence, positive/negative concomitance, undefeatedness or non-opposition.

The fallacy doctrine is not merely a list. It is the negative mirror of **invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**: each apparent reason reveals how inference fails when the middle term does not reliably connect subject of inference (pakṣa) and property to be proved (sādhya).

Critically, Nyaya combines formal and material relevance. It does not validate an argument by form alone; the reason must be objectively connected with the property proved. This strengthens empirical reasoning but makes validity depend on a substantive account of universal relation.

Verdict: The five characteristics and five fallacies form a rigorous diagnostic system, though their success ultimately depends on the contested possibility of knowing invariable concomitance (vyāpti).

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2023 · Q7(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Lists all five positive characteristics accurately.
- Explains all five major fallacy families with examples.
- Maps asiddha, bādhitā and satpratipakṣa to precise failures.
- Shows savyabhicāra/viruddha as concomitance defects.
- Explains the unity of the doctrine through material relevance and invariable concomitance (vyāpti).

2023 · Q8(b) · 15 marks

Question: Write a note on Nyāya notion of Prāgabdhāva (prior non-existence). How does this notion help Naiyāyikas in defending their position on causation against the Sāṃkhya view of causation? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: Define prāgabdhāva's temporal structure, derive its role in new production (ārambhavāda), reconstruct Sāṃkhya's reply, and critically evaluate novelty versus latency.

Independent model answer:

Pragabhava is the beginningless prior absence of an effect in its material cause before production. It has no beginning but ends when the effect arises. Pot-absence exists in clay before pot-production.

This supports **non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)**: the effect as effect is not already actual in the cause. Production terminates its prior absence and begins a new composite entity.

Nyaya argues against Samkhya:

1. If the effect already exists, production is redundant.
2. Cause and effect become indistinguishable.
3. The need for instruments and agents is unexplained.
4. We ordinarily judge "the pot did not exist; now it exists."

Samkhya replies that non-being cannot become being and that a specific cause produces only a specific effect because the effect is latent. Nyaya distinguishes prior absence from absolute impossibility. The pot is absent as an actual whole but possible because appropriate material and causal capacities exist.

Verdict: Pragabhava gives new production (ārambhavāda) a precise temporal ontology. It explains novelty better than latent-effect theory, but still depends on the controversial realism of absences and wholes.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2023 · Q8(b) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- States beginningless-but-terminable prior absence correctly.
- Shows production as termination of prāgabdhāva.
- Uses the doctrine against actual pre-existence of the effect.
- Distinguishes prior absence from absolute non-existence.
- Presents both causal theories before a balanced verdict.

2024 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the six reasons offered by the Naiyāyikas to prove the existence of the self.

Demand decoding: Present six distinguishable inferential routes to an enduring self, explain their common substratum logic, and answer the process-theory challenge briefly.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya infers an enduring self as the substance possessing cognition, desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain, merit and demerit.

Six common routes are:

1. **Memory:** one subject connects past experience and present recollection.
2. **Recognition:** "this is the same" presupposes continuity.
3. **Desire:** present striving refers to previously experienced satisfaction.
4. **Coordination of senses:** one knower integrates colour, touch and taste.

5. **Agency and moral desert:** one agent owns action and fruit.

6. **Possessive awareness:** "I know," "I am happy" presents qualities as belonging to a subject.

Body, senses and sensory mind (manas) cannot alone be self: the body changes, senses are multiple instruments, and atomic sensory mind (manas) coordinates only one cognition at a time.

Buddhists explain these through causal streams. Nyaya replies that succession explains transmission but not ownership and cross-modal unity.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2024 · Q5(b) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Gives six non-duplicative routes centered on ownership and continuity.
- Identifies cognition, desire and effort as qualities needing a substance.
- Distinguishes self from body, senses and atomic sensory mind (manas).
- Uses memory, recognition and cross-sensory unity.
- Notes the Buddhist stream objection and Nyāya's ownership reply.

2024 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Question: Do these two sentences "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire" refer to the same type of absence or absence (abhāva), according to the Vaiśeṣikas? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Classify each sentence by analysing whether it denies a quality in a locus or identity between substances; state counterpositives and explain why the absences differ.

Independent model answer:

No. "Air does not have heat" expresses **atyantabhava** of the quality heat in air: heat is absent from air across times under the school's elemental classification.

"Air is not fire" expresses **anyonyabhava**, mutual absence or difference. Air is non-fire, just as fire is non-air; one entity is absent as the identity of the other.

Sentence	Absence	Counterpositive
Air lacks heat	atyantabhava	heat
Air is not fire	anyonyabhava	fire as identical with air

The first denies a property in a locus; the second denies identity between substances. Both require a counterpositive, but their relational structures differ.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2024 · Q5(c) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Answers "no" without delay.
- Classifies heat-absence as atyantābhāva in the stated Vaiśeṣika framework.
- Classifies air-fire non-identity as anyonyābhāva.
- Uses counterpositive analysis for both.

- Avoids confusing prior absence with atemporal property-negation.

2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and Pramāṇaphala.

Demand decoding: Contrast Nyāya's instrument-result distinction with the Buddhist cognition-centred non-difference thesis and connect both to their ontologies.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya distinguishes **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)**, the instrument or operative cause of valid cognition, from **pramanaphala**, its result. In perception, sense-object contact and the cognitive process generate a true cognition whose practical result may be acceptance, rejection or indifference.

Buddhist epistemologists, especially Dharmakīrti's tradition, treat means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and result as non-different phases of one cognition. A cognition is authoritative by manifesting an object-form and enabling successful activity; no separate enduring knower or instrument-substance is needed.

Nyaya argues that instrument and result must be distinguished to preserve causal explanation: an axe is not the cutting-result. Buddhists reply that cognition is self-performing and self-disclosing; splitting it creates unnecessary entities and temporal gaps.

Verdict: Nyaya offers a richer causal analysis; Buddhism offers event-economy. The dispute reflects their larger contrast between substance realism and momentary cognition.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines both technical terms before comparing schools.
- Explains Nyāya's causal/instrumental separation.
- Presents the Buddhist economy of one cognition without caricature.
- Uses an apt means-fruit analogy and its limitation.
- Links the dispute to substance realism versus momentary cognition.

2025 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Present an exposition of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika's theory of causation.

Demand decoding: Give a compact systematic account of new production, causal relevance, three cause-types and prior absence, with the main rival objection.

Independent model answer:

Nyaya-Vaisesika defends **non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)** or **new production (ārambhavāda)**: the effect does not pre-exist as an actual effect in its cause; it is newly produced when an indispensable causal complex operates.

Three causes are distinguished:

Cause	Function	Pot example
Samavayi	material/inherent cause	clay or constituent parts
Asamavayi	qualities/relations inhering in material cause	conjunction of clay-parts
Nimitta	efficient occasion	potter, wheel, stick

A cause is an *ananyathasiddha* antecedent, not merely anything earlier. Production terminates *pragabhava*. The effect is a real whole inhering in its parts, not merely a collection.

Samkhya objects that non-being cannot arise. Nyaya replies that prior non-existence differs from absolute impossibility and that causal capacity explains determinate production.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2025 · Q5(e) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- States non-existence of the effect before production (*asatkāryavāda*)/new production (*ārambhavāda*) correctly.
- Explains all three causes with one coordinated example.
- Uses *ananyathāsiddha* to distinguish cause from mere antecedent.
- Connects production to termination of *prāgabhāva*.
- Answers the Sāṃkhya non-being objection without implying creation *ex nihilo*.

2025 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: Present a detailed account of Gautama's definition of Perception.

Demand decoding: Quote or accurately reconstruct Gautama's definition, unpack every term, integrate later classifications and critically assess its exclusions and extensions.

Independent model answer:

Gautama defines perception as cognition produced by sense-object contact, **avyapadesya**, **avyabhicari** and **vyavasayatmaka**. Each clause excludes a rival defect.

Indriyarthasannikarsotpanna: Perception is generated by contact between sense and object. External senses apprehend their proper objects; sensory mind (*manas*) mediates internal states.

Avyapadesya: It is not essentially produced by verbal testimony. The clause protects direct presentation from dependence on words and is often associated with the non-conceptual phase.

Avyabhicari: It is non-errant. Illusion caused by defect is not valid perception or valid cognition (*pramā*).

Vyavasayatmaka: It is determinate or definite, excluding doubt. Later Nyaya distinguishes **nirvikalpaka** indeterminate awareness from **savikalpaka** qualified judgement and interprets the definition accordingly.

Ordinary perception includes six contact-relations and external/internal forms. Extraordinary perception includes *samanyalaksana*, *jñanalaksana* and *yogaja*.

Criticisms arise. Buddhists deny conceptual perception of universals; Advaita treats some ordinary cognitions as superimposed; modern critics question extraordinary perception. Nyaya replies that recognition, classification, cross-modal illusion and yogic testimony require a wider contact theory.

The definition also faces a circularity concern: if perception is defined as unerring cognition, how is truth known?

Nyaya uses **external validation (parataḥ-prāmāṇya)**-validity is established through successful activity and subsequent cognition, not built into mere subjective certainty.

Verdict: Gautama's definition systematically excludes testimony, error and doubt while grounding perception in realism. Its ordinary core is strong; its extraordinary extensions are more contestable.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2025 · Q6(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Explains indriyārtha-sannikarṣoṭpanna and each qualifying clause.
- Shows what avyapadeśya, avyabhicāri and vyavasāyātmaka exclude.
- Handles the nirvikalpaka-savikalpaka interpretive issue.
- Adds ordinary/extraordinary perception without replacing definition-analysis.
- Connects error and validity to external validation (parataḥ-prāmāṇya).
- Separates the strong ordinary core from contested extraordinary extensions.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

The following are original, independent practice questions. They are not PYQs and the models are not official UPSC keys.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Why does Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika require both inherence (samavāya) and saṃyoga to explain relations? Discuss with suitable examples.

Demand decoding: Define both relations, apply the dependence and separability tests, show why neither can replace the other, and briefly assess the regress problem.

Independent model answer:

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika distinguishes **saṃyoga** (conjunction) from inherence (samavāya) because contingent contact and constitutive dependence have different ontological structures.

Saṃyoga is a produced and destructible **quality (guṇa)** holding between independently existent substances. A book is on a table by conjunction: both relata can exist separately, contact begins when the book is placed and ends when it is removed. Inherence (samavāya), by contrast, is the sui-generis eternal relation through which specified **ayutasiddha** relata form a constitutive unity. Brown colour inheres in a table; a whole inheres in its parts; cow-ness inheres in an individual cow. The quality or whole cannot first exist independently and then be externally attached as one substance to another.

Reducing inherence (samavāya) to saṃyoga would wrongly turn qualities, universals and wholes into detachable substances. Reducing saṃyoga to inherence (samavāya) would make every accidental contact constitutive and eternal. Nevertheless, **inseparability alone is not sufficient**: two objects may be practically inseparable while remaining conjoined. Inherence (samavāya) requires the standard dependence structure of its relata.

The main objection is relational regress: what relates inherence (samavāya) to its relata? Vaiśeṣika calls it self-linking, a primitive stopping point. This protects systematic explanation, though critics may say it names rather than solves the regress.

Verdict: The distinction is indispensable to the school's realist ontology, but inherence (samavāya) earns its place through explanatory reach rather than independent perception.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 1 · 10 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines both relations through exact ontological criteria.
- Uses the brown-table and book-table contrast correctly.
- Explains why reduction in either direction fails.

- States that ayutasiddhatva is necessary but not independently sufficient.
- Adds the strongest regress objection and a graded verdict.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why comparison (upamāna) and verbal testimony (śabda) cannot be treated as mere forms of perception in Nyāya.

Demand decoding: State the distinctive knowledge produced by each means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), distinguish it from perception, and indicate the conditions under which it becomes valid.

Independent model answer:

Nyāya recognizes **comparison (upamāna)** and **verbal testimony (śabda)** because they generate kinds of fresh cognition not supplied by direct sense-object contact alone.

Comparison (upamāna) yields knowledge of a **word-referent relation through resemblance**. A traveller is told, "A gavaya resembles a cow." On later seeing the relevant animal, she knows, "This is what 'gavaya' denotes." The visual perception supplies the animal, but the semantic identification depends on the earlier description and perceived similarity. It is therefore not bare perception.

Verbal testimony (śabda) is valid verbal cognition arising from the meaningful statement of an **āpta**-a competent knower who communicates without intention to deceive. Its object may concern remote places, history or specialized matters unavailable to the hearer's perception. Linguistic expectancy, compatibility, proximity, convention and correct comprehension are required; defects can defeat the cognition.

Neither means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is infallible. False comparison can arise from misleading resemblance, and testimony fails when speaker, sentence or comprehension is defective. Their independence means a distinctive immediate cognitive operation, not insulation from supporting perceptions or reliability checks.

Verdict: Perception contributes necessary materials, but cannot replace the semantic function of comparison or the communicative function of trustworthy testimony.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 2 · 10 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Identifies the distinctive product of comparison (upamāna).
- Defines verbal testimony (śabda) through āpta rather than any utterance.
- Explains independence without claiming causal isolation.
- Includes validity and defeat conditions.
- Keeps both means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) distinct from perception and from each other.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Nyāya's defence of inference is a disciplined answer to scepticism, not a proof of infallible induction." Examine.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct the sceptical challenge to invariable concomitance (vyāpti), explain the full Nyāya method of securing it and inferential cognition, and judge whether the reply establishes certainty or warranted corrigibility.

Independent model answer:

Inference requires **invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**, the unconditional relation by which the reason (hetu) is pervaded by the property to be proved (sādhya). Cārvāka scepticism attacks precisely this bridge: finite perceptions cannot survey all cases; using inference to prove invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is circular; and an undiscovered **hidden limiting condition (upādhi)** may explain every apparent regularity.

Nyāya's reply is cumulative. The investigator observes repeated co-presence through **agreement in presence (anvaya)** and co-absence through **agreement in absence (vyatireka)**, actively searches for counterinstances, and removes conditioning adjuncts. Wet fuel, for example, exposes why fire does not unconditionally imply smoke. **Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** tests the contrary supposition and removes residual doubt; it assists means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) rather than independently proving the universal. Realism about sāmānya allows **sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** to connect cognition with the universal, although this is the most contested step.

Once invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is warranted, the reason (hetu) must occur in the subject of inference (pakṣa). **Reflective inferential cognition (parāmarśa)**-“this hill possesses smoke pervaded by fire”-is the immediate operative reflection producing inferential cognition. The five-member syllogism makes the warrant explicit for another person. The five hetu-marks and hetvābhāsas then operate as positive and negative diagnostics.

Nyāya also argues that wholesale rejection is unstable. Cārvāka warnings about unknown exceptions and reliance on another's untrustworthiness themselves move beyond presently perceived data. Practical action and inquiry cannot proceed without inferential transition.

Yet the reply does not deductively entail every unobserved case from a finite sample. Its success depends partly on real universals and confidence that relevant conditions can be identified. Thus the Humean residue survives.

Verdict: Nyāya defeats global scepticism by presenting a corrigible, condition-sensitive practice of justification; it is less successful if read as a demonstration of exceptionless induction from observation alone.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 3 · 15 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Presents the strongest finite-sample, circularity and hidden limiting condition (upādhi) objections.
- Explains every major stage of vyāpti-grahaṇa.
- Connects invariable concomitance (vyāpti) to pakṣadharmatā, reflective inferential cognition (parāmarśa) and syllogistic communication.
- Uses hetu-marks and fallacies as error controls.
- Distinguishes defeat of global scepticism from proof of infallibility.
- Gives a balanced verdict tied to universal realism.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Can a self whose consciousness is adventitious meaningfully seek release (apavarga)? Critically discuss the Nyāya position.

Demand decoding: Explain the Nyāya self, the causal chain of bondage and liberation, formulate the “stone-like liberation” objection, and assess the school's reply.

Independent model answer:

Nyāya treats **enduring self (ātman)** as an enduring substance distinct from body, senses and atomic sensory mind (manas). Cognition, pleasure, pain, desire, aversion and effort are qualities that arise when self, mind, senses and objects stand in appropriate relations; consciousness is therefore **not the self's essence**.

The self is inferred through ownership and continuity. Memory and recognition connect past and present cognitions; one subject coordinates different senses; desire and effort refer to experienced ends; moral action and fruit require an enduring bearer. Sensory mind (manas) explains serial attention but, as an instrument, does not replace the owner.

Bondage begins with false knowledge. The soteriological chain runs:

tattva-jñāna -> end of mithyā-jñāna -> end of doṣa
-> end of pravṛtti -> end of birth -> end of pain -> release (apavarga)

Release (apavarga) is **duḥkha-atyanta-nivṛtti**, complete cessation of suffering. With the causal conditions of embodied cognition removed, the liberated self lacks pleasure, pain, desire and ordinary cognition.

The objection is powerful: a wholly non-conscious state appears indistinguishable in value from stone-like existence, and an agent can rationally seek only some experienced good. Nyāya replies that painlessness is intrinsically preferable and permanent; positive pleasure is conditioned, mixed with pain and capable of renewing attachment. The seeker is the presently conscious embodied self, whose rational aim is termination of the suffering-process, not enjoyment within liberation.

This reply is coherent if negative freedom is a sufficient final value. It is less persuasive to traditions that identify liberation with intrinsic consciousness or bliss, because Nyāya's surviving substance seems explanatorily thin.

Verdict: The doctrine is internally consistent: episodic consciousness can motivate release from its painful conditions. Its vulnerability is axiological, not a simple contradiction.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 4 · 15 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Avoids saying consciousness is the self's essence.
- Gives evidence for the self and the role of sensory mind (manas).
- Reproduces the liberation chain and negative definition of release (apavarga).
- States the stone-like objection in its strongest form.
- Gives Nyāya's rational reply and identifies its remaining axiological cost.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Critically examine whether Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika atomism can explain both material novelty and cosmic order without compromising its realism.

Demand decoding: Present atoms, combination, cause-types and new production (ārambhavāda); explain first motion and divine governance; test internal coherence through rival objections; deliver a graded conclusion.

Independent model answer:

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika seeks to explain change without reducing reality either to one substance or to a flux of momentary events. Its material foundation is the **atom (paramāṇu)**: an eternal, partless, imperceptible and element-specific atom of earth, water, fire or air. Partlessness stops infinite division; numerical plurality is secured by **viśeṣa**.

Atoms combine into dyads and larger aggregates until perceptible bodies arise. Gross objects are real wholes, not merely verbal collections: the whole inheres in parts through **inherence (samavāya)**. At dissolution compounds disintegrate, while atoms remain; creation begins when motion and conjunction recommence.

Material novelty is defended through **non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)/new production (ārambhavāda)**. A cloth or tree does not already exist as that actual whole in threads or seed. Its **prāgabhāva** ends when the complete causal set operates. Nyāya distinguishes samavāyi cause (material parts), asamavāyi cause (relevant qualities or conjunctions inhering in those parts) and nimitta cause (agent and instruments). The ananyathāsiddha test excludes merely prior but irrelevant conditions. Thus "new production" is not production from nothing; determinate capacities and materials constrain what can arise.

Cosmic order creates a further problem. Inert atoms and unconscious **unseen causal force (adṛṣṭa)** cannot allegedly initiate purposive first motion or distribute karmic fruits. Nyāya therefore infers Lord (Īśvara) as an omniscient **efficient**, never material, cause. Kāryāt appeals to the effect-character of the world; āyojanāt to atomic arrangement; dhṛtyādeḥ to maintenance; linguistic and scriptural arguments to authoritative order.

Three criticisms follow. First, Sāṃkhya asks why latent causal power cannot explain determinate production without a wholly new effect. Nyāya answers that pre-existence makes production redundant, but Sāṃkhya can distinguish manifestation from non-existence. Second, Buddhists reject eternal simples, wholes and inherence; a causal series may explain compounds without viśeṣa or inherence (samavāya). Nyāya replies that process accounts struggle with stable objects, predication and ownership, yet its primitives remain inferential posits. Third, God appears introduced to animate an otherwise inert mechanism. If action and moral consequence (karma) constrains distribution, divine sovereignty is limited; if God freely governs, evil becomes acute. The reply that God impartially administers beginningless action and moral consequence (karma) preserves justice but does not entirely explain why the order exists.

Atomism therefore combines two explanatory layers: material capacities explain determinate production, while divine intelligence explains initial coordination and moral order. This preserves external realism but increases ontological cost through atoms, viśeṣa, inherence (samavāya), unseen causal force (adṛṣṭa) and God.

Verdict: The system explains material novelty more successfully than cosmic purposiveness. Its causal distinctions are rigorous; its theistic completion is a cumulative explanatory hypothesis rather than a compulsory deduction from atomism.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 5 · 20 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Explains the atom's exact status and combination sequence.
- Integrates viśeṣa, inherence (samavāya) and the three cause-types.
- Distinguishes new production from creation ex nihilo through prāgabhāva.
- Keeps Lord (Īśvara) strictly an efficient cause.
- Engages Sāṃkhya, Buddhist and theistic objections with replies.
- Gives a differentiated verdict on material novelty and cosmic order.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika's greatest strength and deepest vulnerability are both its commitment to realist explanation." Critically evaluate.

Demand decoding: Evaluate the system across categories, knowledge, error, self, causation and God; show how realist explanatory gains generate ontological costs; compare rivals selectively and conclude with a system-level judgement.

Independent model answer:

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika is realist in a demanding sense: stable distinctions in cognition, language and practice generally correspond to structures in a mind-independent world. Its strength lies in refusing to explain away ordinary differences; its vulnerability is the multiplication of entities and relations required to preserve them.

At the ontological level, seven **categories (padārthas)** classify substance, quality, motion, universal, ultimate particularity, inherence and absence. Nine dravyas provide loci for physical and mental qualities. Sāmānya objectively grounds recurrent predication; viśeṣa individuates qualitatively similar eternals; inherence (samavāya) explains constitutive unity; absence (abhāva) gives determinate negative judgement an object. This yields unusual systematic coverage. Yet Buddhist apoha questions universals, relation-regress pressures inherence (samavāya), "self-differentiating" viśeṣa can look stipulative, and negative cognition may not require a negative entity.

Epistemologically, the four means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) match distinct routes to objects. Gautama's perception-definition excludes word-dependence, error and doubt; inference is disciplined through invariable concomitance (vyāpti), upādhi-removal, five hetu-marks and fallacy analysis; comparison (upamāna) explains semantic learning; verbal testimony (śabda) explains social knowledge through āpta. **External validation**

(parataḥ-prāmāṇya) makes validity and invalidity externally ascertainable, enabling correction rather than subjective certainty. However, extraordinary perception stretches realism: sāmānyalakṣaṇa purports to perceive universals beyond a sensed case, and jñānalakṣaṇa mediates absent silver in illusion.

Even error is realist. **Misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti)** locates illusion in a false synthesis of a real present locus and a real elsewhere object. It avoids Advaita's "neither real nor unreal" entity, but critics may judge cognition-mediated contact ad hoc.

The enduring self secures memory, recognition, agency and moral responsibility. Since consciousness is a quality (guṇa) rather than essence, Nyāya can explain discontinuities such as sleep. The price appears in release (apavarga): a self without cognition or pleasure attracts the "stone-like" objection. Nyāya's negative freedom from pain is coherent, though axiologically austere.

Causal realism likewise preserves novelty. New production (ārambhavāda), prāgabhāva, three cause-types and ananyathāsiddha antecedence offer a fine-grained account of production. Atomism explains material persistence across cosmic cycles. Yet compounds require inherence (samavāya), identical atoms require viśeṣa, first motion invokes unseen causal force (adr̥ṣṭa) and God, and moral allocation requires an omniscient governor. Lord (Īśvara) is only the efficient cause, but proofs from effect, arrangement, support and scripture rely on controversial analogies and assumptions about intelligence and order.

The realist may answer that every theory has primitives. Nyāya's criterion is not minimal inventory but maximum coherent explanation of perception, language, negation, identity, causation and responsibility. A rival ontology may use fewer entities by shifting costs into exclusion, momentary series, latent causality or levels of reality.

Verdict: The quotation is justified. Realism gives Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika analytical precision and a unified account of common-sense experience; the same ambition makes inherence (samavāya), viśeṣa, extraordinary perception and Lord (Īśvara) its pressure points. Its achievement is not ontological economy but disciplined explanatory completeness, whose primitives must be defended case by case.

Why this earns marks:

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 6 · 20 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Advances one controlling thesis across the complete printed syllabus.
- Evaluates all seven-category pressure points rather than merely listing them.
- Integrates means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), error, self, liberation, causation, atomism and God.
- Uses Buddhist, Advaita, Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā contrasts selectively.
- Preserves exact doctrinal cautions about consciousness and divine causality.
- Ends with a genuinely graded system-level verdict.